

▽ **Focke-Wulf Fw190 1941****Origin** Germany**Engine** 1,940 hp BMW 801S supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial**Top speed** 408 mph (658 km/h)

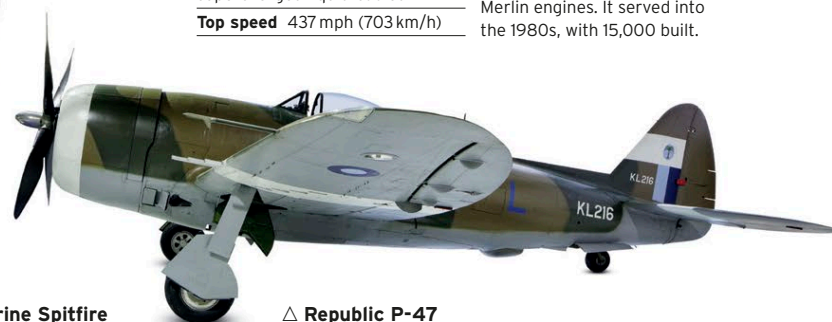
Kurt Tank conceived a radial-engined fighter to beat in-line engined rivals: the Fw190 retained air superiority over the Allies from mid-1941 to mid-1942. More than 20,000 of all variants were built.

△ **North American P-51 Mustang 1944****Origin** USA**Engine** 1,720 hp Packard V-1650-7 supercharged liquid-cooled V12**Top speed** 437 mph (703 km/h)

This highly aerodynamic long-range fighter-bomber had a huge impact on Allied air success, aided latterly by Packard-built Rolls-Royce Merlin engines. It served into the 1980s, with 15,000 built.

◁ **Supermarine Spitfire MkII 1940****Origin** UK**Engine** 1,440-1,585 hp Rolls-Royce Merlin 45 supercharged liquid-cooled V12**Top speed** 357 mph (575 km/h)

Combat superiority from its light weight and aerodynamics made the Spitfire hugely important. The MkII played a key role in the Battle of Britain.

△ **Republic P-47 Thunderbolt 1944****Origin** USA**Engine** 2,535 hp Pratt & Whitney R-2800-59W Double Wasp supercharged air-cooled 18-cylinder radial**Top speed** 435 mph (700 km/h)

Large, heavy, and expensive, Alexander Kartveli's "Jug" (named for its shape) proved extremely effective as a high-altitude fighter and ground-attack fighter-bomber; 15,678 were built.

△ **Grumman F6F Hellcat 1943****Origin** USA**Engine** 2,200 hp Pratt & Whitney R-2800-10W Double Wasp supercharged air-cooled radial**Top speed** 391 mph (629 km/h)

This was a powerful and effective carrier-based fighter of which 12,275 were built. The Hellcat was designed to outperform the Mitsubishi Zero, which was faster than its predecessor, the Wildcat.

▷ **Chance Vought F4U Corsair 1944****Origin** USA**Engine** 2,000-2,325 hp Pratt & Whitney Type R-2800 Double Wasp air-cooled 18-cylinder radial**Top speed** 417 mph (671 km/h)

When first flown, Rex Beisel's Corsair had the most powerful engine and largest propeller of any fighter. The most capable carrier-based fighter-bomber of its time, 12,571 were built.

△ **Yakovlev Yak-3 1944****Origin** USSR**Engine** 1,300 hp Klimov VK-105PF-2 supercharged liquid-cooled V12**Top speed** 407 mph (655 km/h)

Conceived in 1941 the Yak-3 was smaller and lighter than its contemporaries. With a good power-to-weight ratio that made it formidable in aerial combat, it was also easy and cheap to maintain.